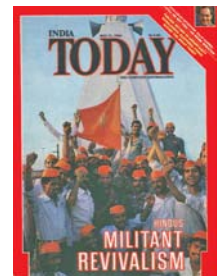
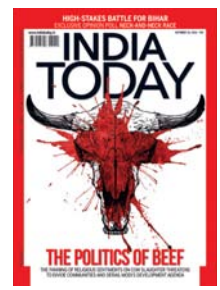
FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Several decades ago, I would frequently be asked at many international conferences what India's future was. Of course, the country has had its ups and downs, but my answer always was that the future is bright regardless of governments because it has a momentum of its own. With one condition. Sectarian violence could upset this upward trajectory. Sadly, my foreboding may be coming true. I see the beginnings of a toxic communal cloud across the country dominating public discourse. We should be debating issues that impact our 1.38 billion population the most—prices, jobs, governance and development, the prospect of another wave of Covid-19, the new education policy, and the right growth model. Instead, witness the sheer explosion of violence or near-violence on Ramnavami/ Hanuman Jayanti on our map. At last count, there were incidents in at least eight states—Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Gujarat, Bihar, Jharkhand, West Bengal, Odisha and, finally, Delhi. The only source of relief is that the death toll is low—one in Khargone, MP, another in Lohardaga, Jharkhand. Earlier, violence broke out in Karnataka over whether halal meat should be permitted to be sold during sacred festival seasons. In the same state, a local battle over banning Muslim women from wearing hijabs in classrooms in a pre-university college blew into a national storm that saw the Supreme Court being dragged in.



May 31, 1986



October 19, 2015



January 29, 2018

India has been in a state of permanent low-grade communal fever over recent months. Controversies over a host of issues have been orchestrated—whether the hijab, halal meat, the muezzin's azaan, *The Kashmir Files* or genocidal calls from saffron-clad sants at sundry *dharam sansad*s and from maulvis issuing equally dire threats. Extremist groups from both sides are guilty of pushing their hardline agenda and goading their flocks into confrontation, with many state governments sadly becoming complacent bystanders rather than enforcing the law. Communal clashes are not new to India. They have been taking place since Partition with varying frequency and for different reasons. The BJP has often used them to polarise the electorate for political gain and others to pander to the minority vote bank. No party is innocent of weaponising religion to attain power. The change is that there has been an increased radicalisation of the general population even when elections are not on the horizon. It is a low-intensity violence embedded at the ground level. Competitive fundamentalism is being driven by extreme elements on both sides.

To understand the consequences of such communal tensions, we invited a gallery of distinguished names to present their thoughts in a series of essays. A universal tone of condemnation fills their words. Even the right-wing commentators are chary of endorsing this spectre of violence. RSS ideologue Ram Madhav, for instance, talks of the "hubris" of Opposition leaders who "pretentiously argue on moral high ground when their own cupboards are filled with horrific skeletons". But he concedes that the voices of hate coming from "sections of Hindus, including some wearing saffron robes, is utterly un-Hindu"—and that "talk of annihilation of an entire community smacks of an attempt at Semitisation of Hinduism". Pro-right scholar Makarand Paranjape too writes that "the deadly dance of mimetic and retaliatory violence...does not augur well for the Republic". Congress leader Shashi Tharoor feels it is no more about one incident or the other—the "toxin" has spread into the very cells of the body politic. Former Union minister Yashwant Sinha laments that "the institutions...supposed to protect our democracy are themselves in need of protection today". Food historian Pushpesh Pant, too, is dismayed by the institutional retreat of the justice system, with "vigilantes taking upon themselves the roles of police, jury, judge and the executioner". NALSAR vice-chancellor Faizan Mustafa points that Muslim communities across the world suffered when Islamic radicalism by a few led to the perception of their religion being one of violence rather than of peace and brotherhood. He warns that the same fate could befall Hinduism "if lumpen elements are allowed to hijack it and damage its image as the world's most tolerant religion". Former editor of the RSS paper *Organiser*, Seshadri Chari, writes: "The larger issue is the responsibility of the leaders of respective communities to rein in the fringe elements and prevail over the troublemakers, by force or legal recourse if needed."

As the divide among Hindus and Muslims is sought to be deepened, is it not time we all came together and debated communally touchy issues in a far more civil manner than resort to street violence? There has to be a middle path between appeasement and demonisation of the minority. Shouldn't all communities condemn the hate, abuse and vandalism currently being unleashed in their names? There is a new generation in our midst, one that has not seen Partition or even the Babri Masjid demolition of 1992. India has survived those traumas—and thrived. Prime Minister Narendra Modi has always maintained that peace, harmony and unity are prerequisites for development. In 2022, as the nation commemorates 75 years of Independence, we should celebrate our unity, showcase our diversity, and shun our divisiveness.



(Aroon Purie)